India’s prime minister was. Obviously this had an impact in the soft power India holds in the world order. For instance, in Japan’s case, Japanese PM Yoshihide Suga had to resign owing to criticism of his COVID-19 handling.[1] But we didn’t see brickbats flung at his dignity in the international media. Under the garb of free speech, these folks went too far, taking liberties which dented the very spirit of India. In October 2021, the prime minister finally let out what he may have thought about the excessive bias in the media against him driven by his opponents. In an interview to *Open* magazine, he reasoned why such a negative situation may have come to be,

> The problem here is not Modi…but when any person tries to see anything with a preconceived mindset, then either he is able to see only half of the view or is inspired to see wrong things. And if he is not able to see anything as per his preconceived notion, then he creates a perception to feed his preconceived mindset. We all know it is the nature of Man to not accept his mistakes easily. It takes courage to accept truth over your wrong notions. And it is because of this that one forms notions about a person even without meeting, knowing or understanding him. And even if they meet you in person and observe something different (as compared to their notion), they will still not accept it just to feed their ego. This is a natural tendency. However, it does not mean that Modi has no faults or there is no point on which Modi can be criticised. I feel, and this is my conviction, that for my own healthy development, I attach a big importance to criticism. I, with an honest mind, respect critics a lot. But, unfortunately, the number of critics is very few. Mostly, people only level allegations, the people who play games about perception are more in number. And the reason for this is that, for criticism, one has to do a lot of hard work, research and, in today’s fast-paced world, maybe people don’t have time. So sometimes, I miss critics.[2]

My view remains that the prime minister should have kept a heavy hand on the states, even if he came across as authoritarian. After the second wave shook the country, not one chief minister came forth to accept blame for their government’s oversight. Not one chief minister admitted that they had been warned over and over by the prime minister—first in the second week of March 2021 all the way until May 2021—about how they need to be